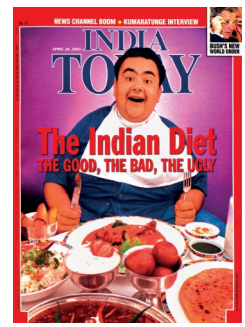
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

India, as we all know only too well, is home to a million culinary delights from a variety of food cultures. It's Diwali, the festival of prosperity and abundance, and chances are that some of those delights are temptingly within reach. Perhaps it's a good time to think about food and its effect on our bodies. In substantial parts of our population, as prosperity levels increase, so does access to a mind-boggling range of edible goodies. With inevitable results. The National Family Health Survey-5, published in 2022, found that 60 per cent of urban Indian women and half of all their male counterparts are in the high-risk category when it comes to waist-to-hip ratio, one of the chief markers of abdominal obesity. The explosion in lifestyle diseases mirrors that. Naturally, visible alongside that is a growing consciousness about maintaining good health. In the long-gone past, we downed Diwali sweets unthinkingly. But now, each time we consume a sinful treat, we get consumed by guilt. We are all aware of the lurking dangers. All of us want to Eat Right, without really giving up on the pleasures of life. But we are bombarded with confusing advice from all directions. Beyond the motto of moderation, what exactly is good for you, or bad for you.

A few inter-related problems smite all of us while trying to make sense of that. There's such a bewildering, and often mutually conflicting, mass of information out there that it becomes a meaningless alphabet soup. Is milk good for you or not? Are eggs to be consumed or condemned? Should you be eating six small meals a day, as nutritionists used to unfailingly advise us till just the other day? Or would that only end up exhausting our pancreas and take us towards insulin resistance? Should we be, on the other hand, trying out the new fad: intermittent fasting? Is it safe to go One Meal A Day? With all questions of this ilk, the basic problem is that the answers depend on who you ask. Even which doctor you ask. Besides, there is no diet that fits all. Every body is different.



April 28, 2003

That ties up with the second problem. Dietetics is an ever-evolving science. Nutrition research keeps throwing up facts that contradict or even upend past knowledge. What was common sense yesterday may be challenged tomorrow in new ways. Received wisdom from even conventional medicine struggles to hold up under contemporary scrutiny. The whole low-fat ideal peddled by the American Heart Association for over half a century, and swallowed uncritically by everyone, is a classic instance. Nowadays, as we all know, they talk more about including 'good fats' in your diet. And in the absence of granular detail, misconceptions ruled the roost. Mutton, for instance, got blanket bad press for decades because of it being a red meat, and almost everyone opted for chicken for health reasons. While there's some reason to do so, did you know goat meat actually has less than half the saturated fat your favourite fowl has? Also, take fruits. Aren't they the healthiest thing you can have? Well, it turns out that fructose is metabolised in the liver, unlike glucose, and makes fat directly. Even inside the liver. So again, choose your fruit wisely. And moderate.

In the face of such bewilderment, a modicum of clarity becomes a universal need. Senior Associate Editor Sonali Acharjee, who has written on a range of health issues for us, brings her wide-angle lens to the cover story this week. Paring down the information overload, curating facts from the latest research, talking to doctors and dietitians, she packs it all into a simple, easily digestible 14-page spread. Facts become relevant when they relate to our experience. What we want to know most of all is how abstract concepts map on to our everyday food choices. What happens when you have a plate of chhole bhature? Or a samosa...or two? Perhaps you are past your favourite pastime of dipping a biscuit in tea and trying to devour it before the thing collapses and dissolves. But even a plain meal of dal-roti gets arraigned in court these days. Not to speak of those little things you don't even notice. "What surprised me the most were the unlikely sources of salt, sugar and bad fat in our diets. Salt in diet sodas, sugar in salad dressings, transfat in tortilla wraps: even what we think is healthy might not really be," says Acharjee.

Luckily, the basics mostly hold true. The human body needs good carbs, good fats and good proteins, all in the right ratio. If you've been fancying a zero-carb diet, know that the brain primarily runs on glucose, so carbs are its most stable fuel. "I would say there is no need to be extreme. Don't torture yourself to cut out a food group if you have no symptoms and simply because others are," Rajeshwari V. Shetty, head of dietetics at Mumbai's S.L. Raheja hospital, tells INDIA TODAY. But why did you never hear about gluten intolerance when you tucked into rotis hot off the tandoor at a highway dhaba back in the 1980s? Because genetic modification of crops has meant that the gluten content in our wheat has gone up sharply from 3 per cent to 30 per cent. And gluten is primarily an inflammatory substance, even if you don't have coeliac disease.

What can you do if you are a firm loyalist of a rice-based cuisine? Simply refrigerate your cooked rice and reheat before having it. That chemically changes its starch into resistant starch: it does not get absorbed in a jiffy and spike up your blood glucose. Or have it with leafy vegetables: that again slows down its uptake. What about the new revival: millets? Yes, all the fuss is justified. They are complex carbs, the good kind, and packed with micronutrients. But there can be too much of a good thing. Millets such as ragi and bajra are very calorie-dense: a mere 100 grams of the latter packs as much punch as a full cup of rice.

Such priceless nuances make up this ready reckoner. Eating Right is an imperative. We are the diabetes capital of the world, with 101 million diagnosed cases and another 136 million with pre-diabetes. That's one-sixth of India potentially headed towards heart disease, in ever-younger stages. That needs to change. But I recall one advice given to me by a health expert: Don't make food your enemy. So, eat mindfully and with joy. Bon appetit and a Happy Diwali.

(Aroon Purie)